

Global Gender Based Violence:

Severity, Legal Gaps & Resource Allocation 2023

This report examines GBV prevalence across 178 countries, analyzing the relationship between legal protections, international aid allocation, and vulnerability outcomes

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Executive Summary

This report analyzes gender-based violence (GBV) within 178 countries with the use of data from the World Health Organization (WHO), United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) and the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD). This report identifies where GBV is most severe, whether legal frameworks reduce occurrence, how trends have developed between 2012 and 2022 throughout the different regions and whether international aid is being allocated towards the countries that need it most

The first main finding was that the severity of GBV is concentrated geographically, particularly in the Western Pacific, Sub-Saharan Africa and the Middle East. More specifically Papua New Guinea (39.8%), Kiribati (37.2%), and Sierra Leone (36.8%) recording the highest IPV prevalence rates globally. Secondly, the level of legal protection is partially responsible with lower rates of violence but the data does not suggest that more legislature alone will improve outcomes. Thirdly there is no correlation between GBV vulnerability and the ODA received suggesting international aid is not being allocated in alignment with GBV need

Methodology

Data Sources

- World Health Organization (WHO): WHO Global Health Observatory Intimate partner violence (IPV) prevalence among ever-partnered women aged 15 and older
- United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC): UNODC Crime Statistics Female homicide rate per 100,000 population
- World Bank Women, Business and the Law: World Bank Women, Business and the Law Safety Legal Topic Score (0–100), measuring the strength of domestic violence and harassment legislation on paper.
- World Bank ODA Indicators: World Bank Development Indicators Net official development assistance (ODA) received per country

Vulnerability Index

A composite vulnerability index was calculated for each country using four components:

- IPV prevalence rate (WHO) weight: 40%
- Female homicide rate (UNODC) weight: 25%
- Legal protection score (World Bank) weight: 20%
- ODA received (World Bank) weight: 15%

Each component was normalized to a 0 –100 scale. Countries missing a severity measure were excluded from the index. Countries missing legal or funding data had those components estimated using median values.

Data Limitations

- UNODC coverage gaps: UNODC homicide data is only available for countries that submitted consolidated total age figures. Many countries with the higher IPV prevalence do not report accurate homicide statistics, creating an inaccurate picture of the prevalence of GBV in those regions.
- Underreporting: GBV is extremely underreported globally. While figures reflect reported incidents, it does not depict true prevalence. Countries with stronger reporting may appear more affected than countries with weaker reporting.

Key Findings

Where was GBV most severe globally?

The Data uncovered the Western Pacific and Sub-Saharan Africa had the highest number of reported intimate partner violence while Europe and parts of East Asia record the lowest rates.

The ten countries with the highest IPV prevalence rates in 2023 are:

Country	Region	IPV Prevalence (%)
Papua New Guinea	Western Pacific	39.8%
Kiribati	Western Pacific	37.2%
Sierra Leone	Africa	36.8%
South Sudan	Africa	36.4%
Equatorial Guinea	Africa	35.2%
Afghanistan	Eastern Mediterranean	35.1%
Vanuatu	Western Pacific	32.0%
Democratic Republic of the Congo	Africa	31.4%
Liberia	Africa	30.8%
Timor-Leste	South-East Asia	30.2%

On the other hand, female homicide data from UNODC communicates something different. The Americas region recorded the highest average female homicide rate for the 2012–2022 period (5.8 per 100,000 in 2012, stabilizing around 4.1 by 2022), driven by countries including Guyana (11.56 per 100,000), Saint Lucia (9.92), Haiti (8.73), Jamaica (8.22), and Honduras (7.66). This discrepancy from IPV prevalence rankings reflects different forms of violence and inconsistencies in homicide reporting among high-prevalence African and Pacific nations.

Are countries with weaker legal protections worse off?

After analyzing the World Bank Safety Legal Topic Score and WHO IPV prevalence rate across all countries the data indicated as legal protections increases, IPV prevalence decreases. However, this explains only a fraction of the discrepancy in violence outcomes. Furthermore, North Macedonia and Costa Rica both scored 100 on the legal safety index, with IPV prevalence of 3.5% and 5.2% respectively, among the lowest in the dataset. Afghanistan, Haiti, Mali, Gaza, and Kazakhstan all scored 0 on the legal safety index. IPV prevalence in these countries ranges from 4.1% (Kazakhstan) to 35.1% (Afghanistan), suggesting that a zero legal score does not uniformly predict the same level of violence outcomes across different social and cultural contexts. Honduras scored 87.5 on the legal index while recording a female homicide rate of 7.66 per 100,000, suggesting strong laws on paper do not guarantee protection in practice when enforcement is weak.

Which regions have improved and which have gotten worse?

Regional female homicide trends were analyzed using UNODC data from 2012 to 2022 across Africa, Americas, Asia, and Europe. Oceania was excluded due to insufficient country reporting. The year 2023 was also excluded due to incomplete reporting at the time of data collection.

- **Americas:** consistently recorded the highest average female homicide rate throughout 2012–2022 period, peaking at 5.81 per 100,000 in 2012 and remaining elevated at 4.12 by 2022. This reflects the influence of countries with high overall homicide rates including Guyana, Honduras, Haiti, and Jamaica rather than a GBV-specific epidemic

- **Africa:** showed significant year-on-year volatility, ranging from a low of 1.61 in 2015 to a high of 3.38 in 2013 and 3.36 in 2021. This is partly attributable to the thin country sample (8–13 countries per year), which amplifies the impact of individual country reporting changes on the regional average.
- **Asia:** showed a consistent decline from 1.27 in 2012 to 0.84 by 2022, representing an improvement trend over the decade and the most consistent positive trajectory of any region.
- **Europe:** remained stable and low throughout, ranging between 0.82 and 1.14 across the full period, with no meaningful upward or downward trend.

Does development aid track GBV vulnerability?

A correlation analysis was conducted between each country's vulnerability score (calculated from IPV prevalence and female homicide rate combined) and the total ODA received in 2023 across 121 countries with complete data on both measures.

The analysis returned a correlation coefficient of 0.015. This confirms that international aid allocation bears virtually no relationship to measured GBV vulnerability at the country level.

The five largest ODA recipients in the dataset illustrate this misalignment clearly:

Country	ODA Received (2023)	Vulnerability Score	Primary Aid Driver
Ukraine	\$38.9B	17.9	Wartime humanitarian aid
Bangladesh	\$5.7B	25.5	Development aid, climate
Ethiopia	\$5.4B	31.5	Humanitarian, food security
DR Congo	\$4.4B	47.4	Conflict and humanitarian
Pakistan	\$4.0B	22.2	Development and climate

Ukraine's \$38.9 billion in ODA reflects wartime humanitarian assistance following Russia's 2022 invasion, entirely separated from GBV vulnerability assessment. Excluding this outlier, the remaining countries' funding levels show no systematic relationship with their vulnerability scores. Only 6 countries in the dataset simultaneously recorded a vulnerability score above 50 and received less than \$500 million in ODA, a surprisingly small number that suggests even high-vulnerability countries are not systematically underfunded in total aid terms, but rather that aid is being directed based on conflict, economic, and political considerations rather than GBV need specifically.

Which countries are most underfunded?

The composite vulnerability index, combining IPV prevalence (40%), female homicide rate (25%), inverted legal protection score (20%), and inverted ODA funding (15%) identifies the countries facing the greatest unmet need across all four areas simultaneously. The top 20 most underserved countries are presented below:

Rank	Country	Region	Income Group	Vulnerability Index
1	Afghanistan	Eastern Mediterranean	Low income	70.8
2	Papua New Guinea	Western Pacific	Lower middle income	70.3
3	Equatorial Guinea	Africa	Upper middle income	69.5
4	South Sudan	Africa	Low income	68.8
5	Guyana	Americas	High income	67.1
6	Kiribati	Western Pacific	Lower middle income	66.6
7	Liberia	Africa	Low income	66.0
8	Democratic Republic of the Congo	Africa	Low income	64.0

9	Vanuatu	Western Pacific	Lower middle income	63.7
10	Haiti	Americas	Lower middle income	63.7
11	Solomon Islands	Western Pacific	Lower middle income	61.2
12	Timor-Leste	South-East Asia	Lower middle income	60.5
13	Sudan	Eastern Mediterranean	Low income	60.2
14	Sierra Leone	Africa	Low income	59.8
15	Samoa	Western Pacific	Upper middle income	59.5
16	Saint Lucia	Latin America & Caribbean	Upper middle income	58.9
17	Dominica	Latin America & Caribbean	Upper middle income	56.9
18	Nigeria	Africa	Lower middle income	55.8
19	Central African Republic	Africa	Low income	55.0
20	Saint Kitts and Nevis	Latin America & Caribbean	High income	55.0

Guyana ranks at 5 with high income, reflecting the country's intimate partner violence crisis (affecting more than 50% of women by lifetime estimates), Additionally a high female homicide rate, reinforcing that income classification does not deter GBV. Similarly, Equatorial Guinea ranks third despite having upper middle income, driven by a high IPV prevalence rate (35.2%) and weak legal protections (safety score: 12.5). The Pacific Islands: Kiribati, Vanuatu, Solomon Islands, Samoa is all overrepresented in the top 20, reflecting a regional pattern of high IPV rates and limited legal and institutional response capacity.

Recommendations

Align ODA allocation with GBV vulnerability

The lack of correlation between GBV vulnerability and aid received represents a failure of the international funding system to direct resources where they are most needed. Donors should adopt GBV vulnerability screening in aid allocation decisions, requiring countries above a defined vulnerability threshold receive a minimum proportion of gender-focused funding using vulnerability data as a primary allocation criterion.

More enforcement of legislation

The legal prevalence correlation confirms that legislation is necessary but insufficient. For example, Honduras has an 87.5 legal safety score combined with a female homicide rate of 7.66 per 100,000 demonstrating that laws without enforcement infrastructure do not protect women. International GBV programs should shift emphasis toward funding enforcement capacity, survivor services, and judicial accountability systems, particularly in the 8 countries in this dataset with a legal safety score of zero.

Invest in statistical infrastructure in under-reporting nations

A critical finding from this analysis is that the countries with the highest IPV prevalence (Papua New Guinea, South Sudan, Central African Republic, Liberia) frequently have no usable UNODC homicide data, creating a blind spot in global GBV monitoring. Funding statistical capacity in these nations is itself a GBV intervention. Without reliable violence data, neither national governments nor international donors can accurately assess need, allocate resources, or evaluate the impact of programs.

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